EPILOGUE

A BLESSING

The taboo was broken. After refusing to talk about Afghanistan for years, Pakistan invited India's external affairs minister, Sushma Swaraj, to deliberate upon Afghanistan at the 'Heart of Asia' conference in Islamabad on 8 December 2015.[1] Though unexpected, the invitation was politically astute. The two South Asian rivals had not been talking for over a year at India's insistence.[2] While their diplomats had been engaging regularly throughout the politically frosty year of 2015, there was no ministerial level dialogue. India wanted to set the terms of talks on Kashmir, and wanted Kabul to push for the same on reconciliation with the Taliban. Displeased by Afghan president Ashraf Ghani's outreach to Pakistan and temporary distancing from India, Swaraj had allegedly snubbed Afghanistan at the 6th RECCA meet held in Kabul in September 2015.[3] In this scenario, if India refused to take up Islamabad's offer, it would come across as being hardline under a Hindu nationalist government, and give Pakistan the moral high ground as a conciliator. But if it accepted the offer, then doors for talks on other potent bilateral disputes such as Kashmir would open up. It was a win-win situation for Pakistan. Contrary to expectations, Swaraj accepted the invitation. There had been a surprise breakthrough in Bangkok where India and Pakistan's national security advisors met shortly after their PMs spoke in Paris in early December 2015.[4] The backchannel paved the way for a comprehensive bilateral dialogue that Swaraj formally announced in Islamabad along with a beaming Sartaj Aziz, her Pakistani counterpart.[5]